pilots ‘of the two coasts’ (meaning the east coast of Africa and the west coast of India) and he was already famous as the author of two books on seamanship that were to remain in use for centuries, so much so that when in 1854 the Victorian explorer Richard Burton embarked in a dhow in the Gulf of Aden he noted that the seaman ‘repeated the Fatiha-prayer in honour of Shaykh Majid, inventor of the mariner’s compass’.[2]

Arab chroniclers claimed that Vasco da Gama had got ibn Majid to pilot his little fleet of three caravels eastwards to India by getting him drunk. The more likely truth is that within minutes of meeting him and seeing his map the Portuguese admiral had offered ibn Majid a fee he could not refuse. Within days the Omani was piloting da Gama’s fleet on the course that brought them to a safe anchorage off ‘the most noble and rich city of Calicut [Kozhikode]’. This was now the busiest entrepot in Asia and the most important staging post in the sea route between China, Africa and the Mediterranean world.

Having learned how to make the sea crossing, da Gama then set about driving a wedge between the Arabs and the local Indian ruler, known by the hereditary title of *Samoothri*, or ‘one who has the sea as his border’, which the Portuguese translated as Zamorin. Da Gama and his fellow Portuguese had been led to believe that the Zamorin, along with his subjects, was a Christian, and for some weeks they managed to persuade themselves that this was so, a fantasy helped along by their loathing of those they called ‘Moors’ – a hatred born of long memories of the Iberian peninsula under Muslim rule. The Zamorin was in fact a Hindu of the powerful Eradi Nair community, with an army of robust Nair warriors at his back, but having no wish to risk his good relations with the Arabs he played safe, leaving da Gama with no option but to leave India virtually empty-handed.